

Interviewer: [00:00:04] Good afternoon. Thank you again for participating in this interview. As I mentioned in my message, I would like to know more about your views on romantic relationships. I believe that your experience and perspective would be a great contribution to the project. Would it be okay for me to record this interview before we start?

Speaker: [00:00:22] There's no problem with that.

Interviewer: [00:00:23] I will only use this recording for transcription.

Speaker: [00:00:27] Okay.

Interviewer: [00:00:28] First of all, how old are you?

Speaker: [00:00:30] [41-45].

Interviewer: [00:00:33] How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker: [00:00:37] It's been [16-20] years.

Interviewer: [00:00:40] Do you have children?

Speaker: [00:00:41] I do, I have a son.

Interviewer: [00:00:44] [1-5]?

Speaker: [00:00:46] I have a son, yes.

Interviewer: [00:00:48] Who do you live with at home?

Speaker: [00:00:51] My wife, my son, me. The [1-5] of us.

Interviewer: [00:00:55] What is your main source of income? What is your current job?

Speaker: [00:01:00] [Occupation].

Interviewer: [00:01:04] How would you like me to address your partner? I can say your husband, I can say your wife, I can say your lover. How should I continue?

Speaker: [00:01:11] We can continue as my wife.

Interviewer: [00:01:15] Can you tell me the story of how you met? How your relationship started?

Speaker: [00:01:21] The meeting is like this. My wife was the daughter of my brother-in-law's brother. I moved to [City] from [City] in the [Year]. At that time, they lived in the same building as siblings. I stayed with my aunt for a while. That's when we met, that's how we met.

Interviewer: [00:01:47] When did you meet?

Speaker: [00:01:50] In [Year].

Interviewer: [00:01:53] So how did your relationship develop? Can you explain a little bit more?

Speaker: [00:01:58] So how did our relationship develop? Let's say it went from friendship in a sense. We were spending more time together. We were in the same apartment building, so we were sitting together in the evenings. We were usually chatting and stuff like that. Then it turned into love (sevgi) over time.

Interviewer: [00:02:21] How do you rate the quality of your relationship compared to your friends' relationships?

Speaker: [00:02:28] I mean, of course there are good ones. There are also those who are worse off than us. I mean, I am not very bad. I can say I am good on average.

Interviewer: [00:02:40] Do you want to elaborate a little bit more on why you say that? Why do you think that?

Speaker: [00:02:46] Now I see the relationships of my friends, and there are things that I have witnessed. Their approaches to each other, their perspectives on life, there are differences. There are those who are in a bad situation, that is, there is not much respect between them. Of course, there are those who are better off than me. I mean, people experience this thing much more emotionally.

Speaker: [00:03:10] Maybe I'm not the type of person who can show that kind of emotion very much. I mean, I don't know if it's because of my upbringing, I guess. Honestly, I'm not the type of person who shows love in a soggy way and lives that way. There are those who do. I see them. I think they're better than me, but since I also see those who are worse than me, I honestly don't find it strange.

Interviewer: [00:03:38] Can I ask you how many romantic relationships have you had in the past?

Speaker: [00:03:43] So let me put it this way. I already met my wife before the [service]. We got married after I returned from the [service]. Before that, we were young, maybe at the age of [16-20] or [16-20], we could call it platonic love. [1-5] or [1-5]. I don't remember much to be honest.

Interviewer: [00:04:05] So how would you rate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker: [00:04:11] So the previous relationship is like this. In the past, in the [Year], it was strange to have such a relationship or even to get up and go out with people like that. Holding hands, I don't know, sharing something, that kind of thing didn't exist. At most you could sit and chat in a corner. Of course, compared to now, I can say more mediocre relationships just for the sake of conversation.

Interviewer: [00:04:46] So, for you, what is it that makes a relationship high quality qualified in your opinion completely?

Speaker: [00:04:54] Trust.

Interviewer: [00:04:57] Can you explain this a little bit more? Why is it like that?

Speaker: [00:05:00] So let me put it this way. Love (sevgi), what is called love (aşk), I think is for a while. After a while, love (aşk) becomes history. Love (sevgi) is permanent. But of course, love (sevgi), how can I call it love (sevgi) with love (aşk) or a different kind of love (sevgi). Or is it the love (sevgi) of habit? I haven't figured that out much, to be honest. But trust is the first priority for me, for example iff I can trust the other person or if I can trust my partner, this is more important to me than anything else. If I can't trust, the others don't mean anything. Because the others don't save me. I think trust is the foundation of a relationship or a marriage.

Interviewer: [00:05:43] So, what makes a relationship low quality?

Speaker: [00:05:47] Lie.

Interviewer: [00:05:48] What makes it unqualified in your eyes?

Speaker: [00:05:49] Lie. So mutually, whether it's a man or a woman. Hiding something, lying about something. When the other person finds out about it. It automatically destroys the relationship.

Interviewer: [00:06:08] You said that trust is the most important thing that makes you qualified.

Interviewer: [00:06:14] So would you say that a secure relationship is a high quality relationship based on what you said?

Speaker: [00:06:21] Well, in my opinion, I would actually say yes. Of course, if you ask whether trust alone is enough in this regard, no. Of course trust has a big share. But respect is also very important in this issue. Trust alone is not enough, this is not a puzzle that is completed alone. Love (sevgi) also has a contribution. It's also a little bit about, how should I put it, trust, love (sevgi) and being nice to people. But as I said, I think the basic issue is trust.

Interviewer: [00:07:03] So can you tell me more about how a person knows that they are in a secure relationship? How does a person know that?

Speaker: [00:07:15] So it's actually like this.

Interviewer: [00:07:17] I'm so sorry by the way.

Speaker: [00:07:18] Relationship... Relationship... It doesn't matter. Feeling safe in the relationship depends entirely on the other person. So it's about the other person to feel that the relationship is safe. If they are disrespectful to you, or if they are in any situation that would shake your trust, or if they say different things about their love (sevgi), that's a total turnoff. In order to feel safe, in order to feel that you are safe, just like I said, you have to be able to trust the other person. And they will trust you. If you can feel this mutually, if mutual respect is intact, if there is a little bit of love (sevgi), you feel that you are safe.

Interviewer: [00:08:05] So when would you say that your relationship is safe?

Speaker: [00:08:11] I mean, when we get married in the first time, before we get married, of course, it's more intense. Until a while after marriage, I don't know, I think in [1-5] years, more love (sevgi) was at the forefront, love (aşk) was at the forefront. Of course, children come into the picture, this and that happens, life circumstances force you. I mean, love gets blocked after a while, it doesn't work anymore. Then there comes a time when the other person is like this, you see them as a friend. Sometimes you see them as one of your own family. Sometimes you see them as your mother. Sometimes you see them as your wife. And because you trust him/her, because you surrender yourself completely to him/her, the relationship continues to work. The part that goes until that moment, maybe [1-5] years, goes with love (aşk). After that, it continues with complete trust and respect.

Interviewer: [00:09:05] So what is your relationship ...

Speaker: [00:09:05] Love (aşk) is not like that, immortal love as other people say, there is no such thing. I think people are wrong there.

Interviewer: [00:09:12] So when would you say that your relationship was the least secure? In this time period.

Speaker: [00:09:21] At certain times, at certain periods, of course, everybody is human, we are human. There were things we hid from each other. There were things that I lied about. During this period, of course, the relationship had reached a very low level. The rate of arguments increased. At that time, yes, the level of the relationship was really low

Interviewer: [00:09:49] So what are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Speaker: [00:09:56] So I will say trust again, I will say respect again. Mutual understanding is also important.

Speaker: [00:10:04] Understanding, trust, respect, love. There are not many options actually. It's like the finger of one hand.

Interviewer: [00:10:09] For you, what is love for you?

Speaker: [00:10:12] I can say that based on what I felt in the early days. We can say it's half of an apple, it's a classic answer, but it's half of an apple. So you see yourself as the other half and you surrender to it. You open up everything. I mean, I don't know, you face all kinds of difficulties together, you share your joys. There is no one from the family with you. For example, my family is far away, in [City]. Some of my siblings are in [City], some in another place. I am alone there. I have only [1-5] aunt. That's my aunt. Naturally, I have no one. And she becomes your family. She suddenly becomes your everything. Since your family is far away, you cling to her completely.

Interviewer: [00:11:05] So, how important is love in a relationship for you?

Speaker: [00:11:11] Love is of course very important in a relationship. Love is the beginning of a relationship. If you don't feel any love or affection for the other person at first, you don't have a chance to take it further. This is a relationship that will be completely blocked. It is something that will end in a certain period of time. So I have to have a love for her, at least at the beginning, and then it is necessary to lay a solid foundation and walk. Afterwards, inevitably anyway. Inevitably, whether it's about the conditions of the world or life, this love continues by turning into different things. But in the beginning, love is very important.

Interviewer: [00:11:53] So, how do you know if your partner, your spouse loves you?

Speaker: [00:12:00] So how do I know that she loves me? My wife for example, let me tell you that she is a very emotional person. Every evening she comes and hugs me and says I love you my love, I love you my love. A person who does not love does not do this. They don't constantly snuggle up to the other person and do not do much. Of course, maybe we have a little bit of a thing here. I'm not the type who shows it like that. I'm not like her. We are a little different. I mean, I don't say "I love you" to her every day, but I'm curious, I ask her every day. What are you doing? That's the difference.

Interviewer: [00:12:39] In your relationship ...

Speaker: [00:12:40] Actually...

Interviewer: [00:12:44] What would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker: [00:12:47] The difficulties in the relationship are actually... Life circumstances are very, very important. If you have a bad life or if your life is not very good economically, the relationship is inevitably shaken. I mean, if you can't meet the expectations of the other person, I'm speaking as a man; when you can't meet the expectations of the other person, it naturally falls a little bit. Basically, you know, people are always looking up. I mean, they envy the person next to them. For example, I think envy is a very big mistake in relationships. I mean, now your friend's spouse lives a different life or his/her friend lives a different life. They are economically freer, economically better off. But let's say she is a wannabe of others. I think it actually brings the relationship to a dead end. We have lived through a period. So being a wannabe is really not a very good thing. I mean, this is what I can do. I can do this much, but different people can live differently. Rich people can live differently. I don't have the chance to live like them. They have to accept it like that, but sometimes they can't accept it. So I think living conditions are an important factor in this regard.

Interviewer: [00:14:11] Well thank you. Do you and your wife fight?

Speaker: [00:14:17] Do we fight, of course we do sometimes. I mean, when I say fight, it's more like an argument. I don't remember many such fights. But of course we have arguments, as in every family. We didn't have many such things in the early days, but after we had children, it started to increase more. Because the influence of the child was too much. We had more disagreements over the child. What she says is different, how should I put it when raising the child; I'm a bit more authoritarian, you know, more disciplined. I tried to raise the child that way because that's how we were raised. Of course, mothers are a little different. She couldn't stand them too much, she didn't want to. We had many arguments there.

Interviewer: [00:15:00] And can you tell us how often these fights happened?

Speaker: [00:15:07] I mean, maybe every [1-5] or [1-5] months. I mean, after the child was first born, how should I put it, after the child was born, maybe it happened more often at the age of three to five. Maybe once every [1-5] weeks, but it didn't last very long, to be honest.

Interviewer: [00:15:25] So how do you resolve these fights?

Speaker: [00:15:30] My wife is a little bit more, how shall I say, withdrawn in nature. She doesn't push me too much. In general, she actually ends it. After reaching a certain level, she stops, turns around and leaves. Naturally, it causes the fight to cool down in this way.

Speaker: [00:15:50] I can't be unfair to my wife for that. I am a little bit more of a nervous, irritable type. But of course, when the other person stops it, you automatically stop too.

Interviewer: [00:16:04] So other than your spouse leaving, what do you think are the other ways of maintaining your relationship?

Speaker: [00:16:12] I mean other ways... I swear we haven't had anything like this for a long time. I don't remember. Let's say it is somehow on track now. I mean, it can actually be the other way. I'm not the same as I used to be. I don't know, [6-10] years ago I had a very different personality. Maybe as you grow up or as you get older, you see different lives, you constantly gain experience. Let's say this calms you down a little more. So the me of today and the me of [6-10] years ago are very different. Maybe this continues to keep the relationship a little more grounded.

Interviewer: [00:16:54] So would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Speaker: [00:17:00] Of course, for me, I am in the position of what more can I ask for. We are doing very well, thank God. We have a child who is [16-20] years old. Somehow we raised him one way or another. We had hard times. There is nothing better. I mean, I don't think there is. Not for me. Now I see other people, I see other lives, people seek so many different things. So that's not the case for me. Thank God we have come this far. I hope we will go on from now on.

Interviewer: [00:17:32] Has this relationship changed you?

Speaker: [00:17:36] Of course.

Interviewer: [00:17:37] How did it change you?

Speaker: [00:17:41] Actually, first of all, it changed me in terms of thinking. We had a childhood with a tough upbringing in terms of thinking. I mean we were raised very strict. We were raised in a very disciplined, very different way. Naturally, this harshness continued for a long time. Maybe it continued until the age of [30-35]. Let's say we got rid of it. I mean, I left my family at the age of [16-20]. I've been taking care of myself since then, to be honest. I take care of my own family without being a burden on anyone. Maybe it was a very difficult time for me. I mean, at that time, I got up and came to [City] from [City] without any support from anyone. Think of it as coming from the village to the city. I didn't know anything about the city. I learned everything here. By working, by constantly working. In fact, working wastes a lot of time and space in my life. I guess I have a weakness for working a bit too much. In fact, there were times when it brought us against each other, yes, because of this work. Because when you work too much, you can't spare time for your family. Think about it now, you're going to talk and the answers to the questions you ask come to your mind. For example, I would never have thought of these things. Yes, I mean, when we work, I'm working now, but at least there are criteria at certain levels now. We were very troubled.

Interviewer: [00:19:15] So, did your partner change during that relationship?

Speaker: [00:19:20] For sure. I mean, of course she had a much different nature at first when we got married. She had a much different perspective on life. But let's say time has taught us a lot, educated us. After a while, she had to change too. She changed too, he changed a lot. The me or her of the early days doesn't exist now. There are no such people. There are completely different people.

Interviewer: [00:19:49] I was going to ask if the person you were before the relationship is the same person you are now, but you already answered...

Speaker: [00:19:55] You have your answer yes. it is not the same unfortunately.

Interviewer: [00:20:00] Do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker: [00:20:03] Yes. I don't have any insecurity about my life right now or about my relationship. I have no insecurity about my wife. Thank God. I don't want to have any. Insecurity is not a very good thing. It is an abyss for me.

Interviewer: [00:20:21] Do you want to elaborate a little bit more on why you say that?

Speaker: [00:20:25] About mistrust?

Interviewer: [00:20:25] Why you think that. Uh-huh.

Speaker: [00:20:30] So once you lose trust in a person, there is no going back. That relationship can never be saved. No matter how much love (aşk) there is in it. If there is no trust, it automatically means there is no respect. When you lose both of them, love (sevgi) or affection has no meaning, it has no validity. So you have no chance to go one step forward. That relationship basically has to end. It will end sooner or later. So let's say this very clearly in the sense that if there is no trust, there is nothing.

Interviewer: [00:21:08] So can you give concrete examples of this?

Speaker: [00:21:13] Here's the thing about trust. I had a friend. Unfortunately, his wife was not a very trustworthy type, he did not see it himself. But there were many things we saw as friends. But when we went and told this to our friend, unfortunately our friendship ended. But later we heard that after a while my friend separated from his wife. And this is not just one example. We have had many such examples in our lives, in our circle of friends or close relatives. I am saying this here because we have witnessed all this.

Interviewer: [00:21:53] So now I'm going to show you a scale, I'm going to show it to you so you can visualize it, I'm going to read it at the same time. If I ask you if my partner usually really listens to me. One is not true at all, nine is completely true. What would be your answer in the scale range?

Speaker: [00:22:15] So it's like this. Let's say it's partially true. Six.

Interviewer: [00:22:20] May I know why you say six? Why not five or seven?

Speaker: [00:22:25] Like this. I mean, not everything I say is right. Sometimes what I say can also be wrong. I may not see it, I may be thinking differently at that moment. Or I might be thinking wrong. It's not that I am or I am not, we are all human. Sometimes we are surprised. Naturally, she doesn't agree with everything I say. She also expresses her own opinion, she says no, you are thinking wrong here. I don't agree with this or I don't want this. She gives her answer and gives his reason. Then, of course, after we sit down and think about it, maybe that's when we realize that the fault lies with us. Or there is no such thing that a mistake in our thinking will necessarily accept my thinking, so people are mutual, she has an opinion and I have an opinion. We are trying to find the common ground.

Speaker: [00:23:18] So whichever one doesn't make more sense, she gives her opinion. Maybe it makes more sense. There were times when I said, "Oh, you're right, that makes more sense.

Interviewer: [00:23:25] You answered six. May I know why you didn't say five or seven?

Speaker: [00:23:30] So five already partially agree with the truth, I haven't seen the thing.

Interviewer: [00:23:36] So five is completely, partially correct; six is one ahead of that.

Speaker: [00:23:42] I saw it as six partially correct. So six is like this. Actually, I said that six is partially correct in the first place. I said six is partially correct. I said it like that because I didn't see it in the range. I can explain partially correct in this way. Partially correct. Yes, it is. Sometimes she agrees, sometimes she disagrees.

Interviewer: [00:24:03] I would say that my partner is usually sensitive to my needs. Again from one to nine. That's not true at all. Nine is completely correct.

Speaker: [00:24:15] Seven. I mean, in general, if I don't say what my needs are, if I don't say it, I can say it more without saying it, I mean, this is the simplest example, it can be clothing. There may be something I want but I may not buy it. I may not be able to buy it. She usually acts according to my wishes. I don't say it. I'm not the type who wants a lot. I don't want much. She goes and gets it and says you wanted that, you liked it, you liked it.

Interviewer: [00:24:44] You answered seven. Why? Not eight or six. It's seven.

Speaker: [00:24:49] So six is partially true. It's not wrong partially right. It's doing it in general. Nine. Not all of it. So I can't say that she does everything I want. Sometimes what I want is against her. She doesn't do it. But in general, it makes more sense to tell the truth.

Interviewer: [00:25:12] I hope you don't mind me asking. If this is too sensitive for you to share, please feel free to say so. But I would like to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker: [00:25:27] Like this. So my wife is in menopause now. Naturally, we don't have the chance to have intercourse very often.

Speaker: [00:25:37] Because it takes a little longer during menopause, her disease is that she is constantly bleeding. She also went to the doctor, of course, she also talked to her doctor. She is a little more sensitive in this period. I think she also feels under such pressure. I don't go over it too much. I mean, it's completely something that current life requires. But you say before menopause. On average two or three times a week.

Interviewer: [00:26:07] How satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker: [00:26:11] I am satisfied. I have no problems. I mean, after a certain age, I think sexuality takes a back seat. Because it has no meaning. I mean, now you look at people like this, [50-60] years old, [65-70] years old, they are walking around like a horny goat, in vulgar terms. This is meaningless and illogical. I mean, I have already shared a lot with my wife. Physically, our relationship is in a good condition. But I said that right now it's a little bit more downwardly normal because of the illness. I don't find this strange either. I mean, these are completely natural things in life. I don't know how it will be from now on.

Interviewer: [00:26:55] So how satisfied are you with your relationship in general? Completely satisfied, completely dissatisfied, very dissatisfied, somewhat dissatisfied, not sure, undecided, somewhat satisfied, can you see?

Speaker: [00:27:09] I see.

Interviewer: [00:27:09] I'm very satisfied. I'm completely satisfied.

Speaker: [00:27:14] So I can say that I am very satisfied. Now you will ask why you don't say that you are completely satisfied. I mean I didn't say that I am completely satisfied. Because there is no perfect relationship. I don't think there is a relationship where everything can act at such a high level, I mean maybe there is, but it is very rare, but I don't have it. I mean, there are things that we are conflicted or we avoid from time to time, or there is a matter of argument. If you say you are completely satisfied, none of these things should have happened. This is also

not possible. In a relationship or in a marriage, if nothing happens in the same house, a fight breaks out because of the child and it breaks out again.

Interviewer: [00:27:58] So if I ask you to rank it. From zero to ten. From not at all satisfied to completely satisfied. How many would you give?

Speaker: [00:28:06] Or I want to give nine to that.

Interviewer: [00:28:11] Why not 8 or 10?

Speaker: [00:28:14] I mean, I just explained why not 10. Of course, as I said, nothing is perfect. That's why I didn't say 10. I mean, of course, in some places, both she and I sometimes get angry, get angry, have a fight. That's why I didn't say 10, but that doesn't mean that we are not satisfied, that's why I didn't say 8. I mean, of course I am satisfied, I am satisfied, but I am neither completely satisfied nor less satisfied.

Interviewer: [00:28:49] Did your relationship meet your expectations?

Speaker: [00:28:54] So yes, in general she welcomed it. My wife is very hardworking. She has worked since she was [16-20] years old. I have never seen her exclude me, for example. She has worked for years and years, and I have never once seen her take her money and say, "This is my money" and step aside. Every time she went and took her salary and came and gave it to me. She said, "Here, my dear, what do we have to pay, what do we have to do, can we get this, can we get that?" I have seen her support in that regard.

Interviewer: [00:29:37] We're about to finish. I'd like to summarize what we talked about in the last half hour. You said that you were generally satisfied with your relationship. You said that the most important thing in the relationship is respect and trust. You said that we fight sometimes because of the children, but that my wife and I don't have any problems in general. Was that true?

Speaker: [00:29:58] Yeah, right

Interviewer: [00:29:59] Is there anything else you would like to add?

Speaker: [00:30:03] I have nothing to add. I mean, marriage life or relationships change according to each person's point of view, it changes according to each person's, I don't know. This is the way it is for us, at least for me. Probably there are differences in my wife. Her point of view may be different. She will express her own opinions, probably because you will probably discuss it with her. I'm like this, I see it this way. People may see it differently. I don't have much to add. This is my life. Everyone probably looks at their own lives.

Interviewer: [00:30:43] Thank you very much. Before we finish I would like to talk to you about how we are going to handle the data. As a research project I want to be as transparent as ethically possible. And so I would like to know which data sharing option is most suitable for you. I am going to read you two options. You can choose one of them, whichever one you want. The first option is to share parts of the transcript of our interview. None of these transcripts will contain any identifying information about you. So our de-identified interview transcript can be read by other researchers. The second option, if you don't mind and if you want to be a bit bolder, is to share the whole interview transcript, stripped of sensitive and overly identifying details, so that it is anonymized. There is a very small chance that someone who knows you well will be able to piece together the details of the interview transcript and narrow it down to the

choices of who they believe you are among colleagues. Again, no sensitive information will be shared. Which of the two options do you prefer?

Speaker: [00:31:47] I mean, I don't have anything that can't be shared. My credentials don't have to be shared anyway, so if it helps, it doesn't make any difference to me. You can share all the documents.

Interviewer: [00:32:00] Then it's the second option, right?

Speaker: [00:32:03] Yes.

Interviewer: [00:32:05] Thank you.

Speaker: [00:32:06] So that might show something different to people, maybe to those who read it, that everybody is running after love and romance, and maybe they can realize that what they should be running after is something different, so it's okay.

Interviewer: [00:32:20] Thank you very much again for participating in this study, and I want you to know that this study has been done in the Philippines, Brazil, the Netherlands, France, and the United States, and there is one more thing that I would like to ask you, if it's okay with you, for this study to be a success, would you suggest two close people in your life as candidates? Either I will not see the people you suggest, or I will ask them to suggest other couples.

Speaker: [00:32:45] So it's like...I would like to help you but unfortunately people are very different now.

Speaker: [00:32:52] I mean, I don't think I have such people around me right now. I'm sorry for that, I can't help you.

Interviewer: [00:33:12] Thank you very much. I'll stop the recording.